The Care Leaders
Learning

Keynote workbook

Living a Careless Life

Understanding the lived experiences of children in care

Luke Rodgers BEM



What this keynote gives you

Use this workbook during the keynote to catch what stays with you, and afterwards to put it to work.



By the end you will be able to

1. **Understand** the impact of the language we use about children with a social worker.
2. **Explain** how attachment and trauma shape the nervous system.
3. **See** how school and children's social care clash, and who pays for it.
4. **Use** four practical tools to support young people.

How to use it



Hold one young person in mind. Someone you are trying to support right now. Keep them with you all the way through.



It is not a test. There are no right answers. Write what is true, including the uncomfortable parts.



Look after yourself. Some of this may bring up your own experiences. Take a break whenever you need one.

Your way through

Story
Meet Jay and Sam. Notice what you assume.

Theory
Language, the brain and the two timetables.

Action
Four tools, then back to Jay.

Start here: the lighter

A composite story. It draws on real experiences but is not one person. Read it, then answer honestly.



Jay, 14

It's period four on a Wednesday and Jay's science class is lighting Bunsen burners for the first time. Jay has been in his foster home for six weeks and this is his third school in two years. He is quiet in lessons and mostly keeps his head down.

The gas taps are on and nobody can find the striker. While the rest of the group waits, Jay takes a lighter out of his blazer pocket and lights their burner. A couple of the others laugh.

Mr Hughes sees it from across the room. He goes red and points at the door. "Out. Now."

Jay stands in the corridor for ten minutes. When Mr Hughes comes out he is still angry. "Give me that. Where on earth did you get a lighter from?"

Jay looks at the floor. "It's my mum's," he says. Then, quietly, "I don't live with her any more. I'm in care."

Mr Hughes stops. Nobody had told him. His face changes completely. He hands the lighter back and says, "Just keep it in your bag, OK?"

The lighter wasn't his mum's. Jay got it from a friend.



You are Mr Hughes. Jay has just told you he is in care. What do you say next?

What happened to your anger when you read his answer?

What would you do with the lighter?

Keep your answers. We come back to Jay on page 17.

1 Story

Meet Sam. First you will read what is written about Sam. Then you will read Sam's story.



In this section

The words we inherit about children with a social worker, Sam's profile, Sam's story, and two scores that show you how much words matter.

Where you are

Story	**Theory**	**Action**
You are here	Next	Then

We inherit words

What words do we use to describe children with a social worker? Somewhere, without meaning to, we store them. Then they start to do our thinking for us.



Challenging | High risk | Vulnerable | LAC and CIN | Damaged

What the word quietly becomes

Challenging	"They are going to display challenging behaviour."
High risk	"They are dangerous to be around."
Vulnerable	"They cannot look after themselves."
LAC and CIN	"They are lacking and in need."
Damaged	"They are broken."

They are broken » They are unfixable » I can't help

Which words have you heard, or used, this month?

Meet Sam, 16. Everyone writes about Sam.

A profile is a statutory document. It can go by different names. It often arrives long before the young person does.



Sam's profile

Is at high risk of absconding.

Persistent young offender with offences including burglary and affray.

Known to deal and has been caught with drugs at school.

Has stolen previous foster carer's car in the night.

Low attendance at school and is disengaged with other pupils.

Has issues with attachment.

Isolates themselves in their room. We are seeking psychological assessments as we think it links to early childhood trauma.

Disruptive behaviour when confronted with authority, and their "outbursts" are hard to control.

Struggles to follow simple house rules when living in a foster placement.

Hard to build a rapport as can be guarded and "closed".

Pause. On your own, score these from 1 (low) to 10 (high).

How confident would you be offering Sam a place in your school, home or service? **/10**

How concerned would you be about Sam? **/10**

Hold these answers.

Sam's profile, and Sam's story

The same events, read twice. On the left is what was written. On the right is what was actually happening.



What was written	What was happening
High risk of absconding	Was late home.
Burglary and affray	Took their own things from their parents' house without asking. Sam was attacked for it.
Known to deal, caught with drugs	Smoked some weed with friends at school.
Stole a foster carer's car	Frightened and lonely, drove to see their mum. This happened once.
Low attendance, disengaged	Always being moved school. Just wants friends.
Issues with attachment	Struggles to feel safe with people.
Isolates in their room	When reminded of an abusive family, goes to their room and is often found crying.
"Outbursts" with authority	Lived where abuse was normal. Gets scared when they hear shouting.
Struggles with house rules	Has lived in so many places the rules keep changing. Hard to keep up.
Guarded and "closed"	**Sam just wants to be loved.**

Score again. Confident to offer Sam a place? Concerned about Sam? Compare with page 6.

/10 /10

"I can't help" becomes "I want to help."

What changes when the language changes

Did your scores move? What moved them?

2

Theory

Why the language sticks, what Sam's brain learned to expect, and how two systems clash.



In this section

Unconscious bias and the three problems language creates. Attachment and trauma, and two principles of the brain. The two timetables.

Where you are

Story	Theory	Action
Done	You are here	Next

This is unconscious bias

The associations we hold, outside our conscious awareness and control. It is an umbrella term. Five kinds showed up in Sam's profile.



1	2	3	4	5
Age bias	**Gender bias**	**Anchor bias**	**Horns effect**	**Confirmation bias**

Make a note of each one as Luke explains it.

The language we use creates three problems

Redundancy
We don't feel we have the skills to help.

Judgement
We wrongly judge young people.

Rejection
Young people are rejected.

> **"Changing words won't change worlds. We need to know our young people."**
>
> **Luke Rodgers BEM, Lived Experience Leader**



What Sam learned before 10

Mum was non-nurturing. Dad was neglectful and absent. Step-dad was strict and abusive. A quick look at child development shows what that taught Sam.



0 to 4 years

Developing: relationships with parents · first attachment style · wanting their attention · trust · the roles of mum and dad

"My parents don't love me. They are always fighting and when I cry no one comforts me."

"I can't trust my parents. They don't keep me safe."

"My dad hits my mum, and my mum doesn't seem to care about me."

5 to 10 years

Developing: logic · copying adults · ideas of male and female roles · learning good and bad · relationships with peers

"My parents shout at each other, so I should shout too."

"Dad and step-dad are violent. That's what it means to be a man."

"Shouting and hitting are good. It's what my parents do."

"I will have relationships like the ones I have with my parents."

Also known as attachment theory.



The brain has two principles

It looks for patterns, and it is built to survive. For Sam, the threat might not be a snarling dog. It might be a relationship.



1

Pattern seeking

The brain sorts the world into familiar and unfamiliar. When we try to comfort Sam, the brain may read it as a threat, because relationships in the past were threatening.

2

Survival orientated

When we are scared, the brain goes into survival mode. Walter Cannon described fight or flight in 1915. We now talk about five responses.

Fight | **Flight** | **Freeze** | **Flop** | **Fawn**

When we see a red flag

Adults: likely logical and regulated	Children: likely emotive and unregulated
Call a friend	Become triggered
Communicate boundaries	Push people away
Sit with the emotion	Panic

"Connections on the outside build connections on the inside."

Dr Becky Bailey

Two timetables

Sam lives on two timetables at once: school's and children's social care's. Only the headteacher and the designated teacher know Sam is in care. When the two clash, Sam pays.



What school sees	What social care was doing
Missed a lesson. Absconding?	Seeing their social worker, or in a review meeting.
No PE kit. Detention.	Lost in an emergency move to a new foster home.
Late on Monday. Another sanction.	Trying to call a social worker who starts at 9, after school has started.
Homework not done.	

Two common approaches. Where is your natural position?

Behaviourist — **Nurturist**

Sanction and reward · routine · discipline

Behaviour is communication · compassion · relationships

Mark where you sit on the line. It is a spectrum, not a side.

Sam says: "I don't want anyone to know I am in care."

Why do you think Sam doesn't want people to know? What do you do?

3

Action

Four tools you can use with a young person this week. Then back to Jay.



1 Just say yes · end the cycle of rejection Page 15

2 Spot, Soothe, Shift · being a safe adult Page 15

3 Challenging stigma · five steps Page 16

4 Separating Reason from Behaviour Page 17

Tool 1: Just say yes

If we agree the words in Sam's profile are wrong, changing how we record is not enough. Sam is being turned away today. So until the words change, we ignore them.



1

Ignore what is written

Meet the young person, not the file.

2

End the cycle of rejection

Every no confirms what Sam already believes.

3

Just say yes

To the place, the school, the home.

Tool 2: Spot, Soothe, Shift

Being a safe adult, to help young people learn to trust. Use it when a young person is showing signs they don't feel safe.



Spot
what they are saying

"I hate them." "I've had such a bad experience." "You don't care." "I can't do that because of..."

Soothe
communicate safety

"I can see you are hurting. It will be OK." "That wasn't your fault. You are safe."

Shift
redefine the narrative

"In the future you will be..." "I believe this experience will make you..."

Watch out. A disclosure is never shifted or reframed. It goes straight to your safeguarding lead.

Tool 3: Challenging stigma

When a young person tells you they don't want people to know they have a social worker, it is usually because they expect to be judged. If we don't challenge that, we are quietly agreeing they will be.



Use these five steps

1. **Tell them they will not be judged**
   And if they ever feel they are, they come to you.
2. **Explore both scenarios**
   Talk through what it looks like if teachers do know, and if they don't.
3. **Involve them in the decision**
   Agree together what to say to teachers in either case.
4. **Don't take their first answer**
   Ask them to go away for a couple of days and think about it.
5. **Tell them you want to have their back**
   Whatever they decide.

Your turn: which step would you find hardest with the young person you have in mind, and why?

Tool 4: Separating Reason from Behaviour

Holding young people accountable in a way that gives them ownership to change. Adapted from emotion coaching.



1

Recognise the reason

An emotion or a reason behind it.

2

Offer support

Personally, or by seeking it.

3

Highlight the behaviour

Separate it from the reason.

4

Give ownership

Create accountability.

Back to Jay. When a young person alarms and disarms you

Sometimes a young person shares something personal that stops you in your tracks. Your anger drops, and the behaviour slips past. This is how Mr Hughes could have used the tool.

1. **"Thanks for telling me. I wasn't aware."**
2. **"I want you to know you can talk to me about this, or to our designated teacher. We want to make sure you have support."**
3. **"Lighters still aren't allowed in school."**
4. **"I'll keep it in my drawer. Come and see me at the end of the day and you can have it back, and we'll agree it stays at home."**

Look back at what you wrote on page 3. What would you change now?

We have a duty to break cycles

Three things to avoid, three things to take with you, and one thing you will do.



Avoid three things

Personalising the system

Excusing behaviour

Worrying you will get it wrong

Key learning

1 **The words written about a young person shape whether anyone says yes to them.**

2 **Behaviour that looks like defiance is often a survival response to past relationships.**

3 **A safe adult can hold a boundary and still keep the young person close.**

This week, with the young person I have in mind, I will

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Watch it again

You have access to the recording of this keynote for 12 months. We will email you the link as soon as it is ready, so look out for an email from The Care Leaders.

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From care leaver to care leader

Story · Theory · Action